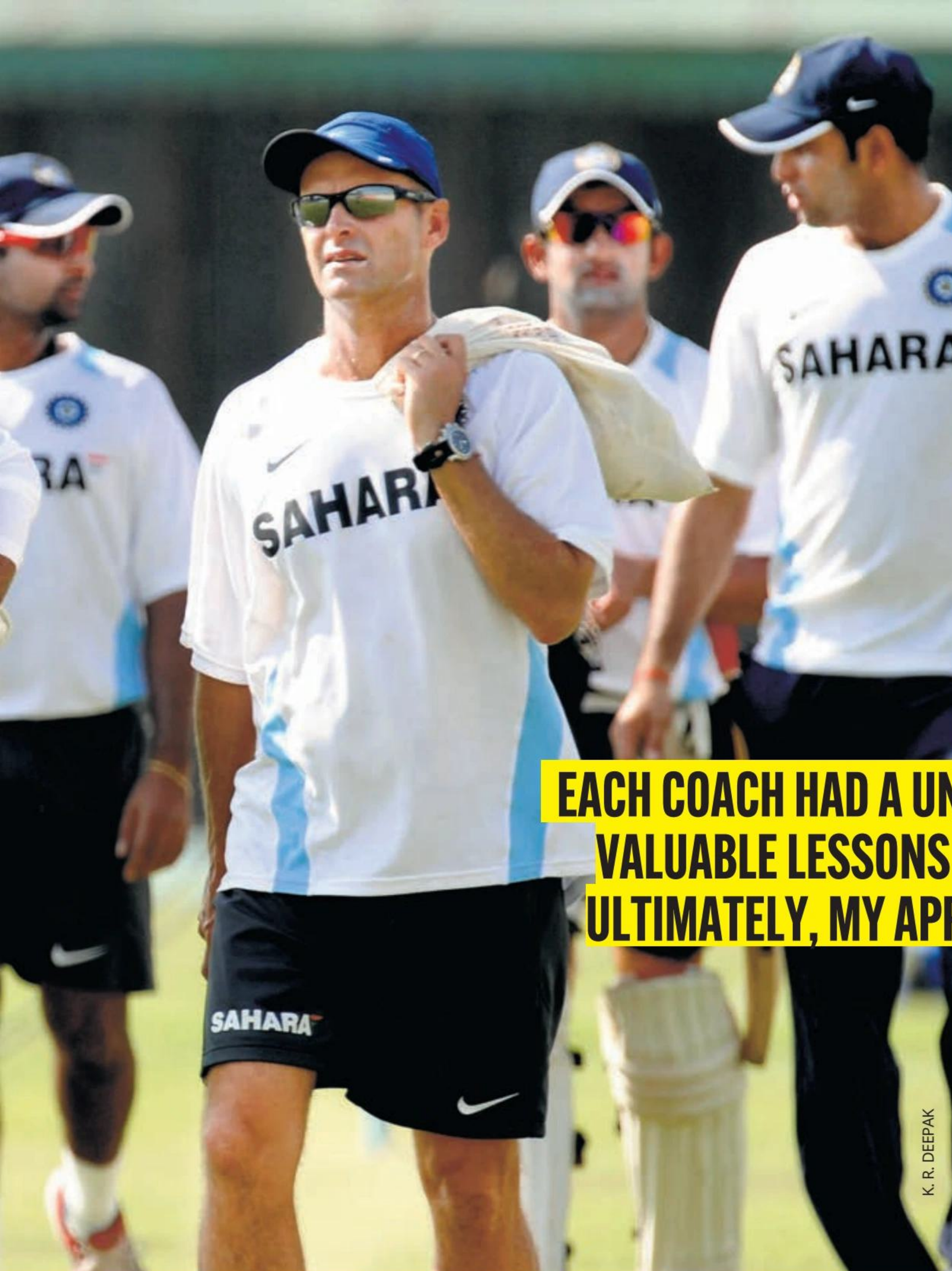




K. R. DEEPAK

EACH COACH HAD A UNIQUE STYLE, AND I TOOK VALUABLE LESSONS FROM ALL OF THEM. BUT ULTIMATELY, MY APPROACH REFLECTS WHO I AM AS A PERSON

tournaments like the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy and, to some extent, the Vijay Hazare Trophy, which are now seen as stepping stones to the IPL.

While it has made the season longer and more demanding for players, the benefits — exposure, financial security, and a competitive environment — far outweigh the challenges.

Do you think cricket could follow football's path, where clubs take precedence over international teams?

There's no doubt that leagues are growing rapidly. With increasing investment and expanding schedules, they will play an even bigger role in the cricketing calendar.

That said, I still believe international cricket will remain the primary focus. It carries the history and tradition of the game, and I hope it continues to be a critical part of the schedule. However, leagues are becoming more influential, and the challenge will be to strike the right balance. Ideally, both international and franchise cricket can coexist without one cannibalising the other.

How challenging is it for Royals to manage two home bases, with Guwahati now designated as the second home?

Managing two home bases is definitely a challenge, but it's also an opportunity. Playing in Guwahati allows us to grow the game in the

Northeast and build a fanbase there.

We saw fantastic support in the two games, especially against CSK and KKR. Of course, in the CSK match, their fans outnumbered ours, which was expected. But overall, it's been great to see the enthusiasm for cricket in Guwahati.

From a cricketing perspective, we must keep learning to adapt. It's still early days, but we'll find a way to establish two strong home grounds. Since we play only a couple of games in Guwahati, it doesn't feel as much like a home advantage yet. But as we continue engaging with fans here, we hope to make it a strong second home in the future.

With Kumar Sangakkara transitioning to director of cricket and you now leading the IPL campaign, how has the core team adapted to this change? What conversations have you had with the players?

My philosophy is to work closely with the captain and players — they drive the culture and vision. That hasn't changed, which is why we retained our core group.

Sanju leads the team, and our job is to support him with the right information and environment to succeed. It's a collaborative effort between me, the support staff, and the team, not just me imposing my approach.

I like the brand of cricket Royals play, and having been here before, I understand the setup.

We aim to be an exciting young team, push boundaries within our skillset. We want to evolve naturally rather than make changes for the sake of it.